July 04, 2025 06:42 PM · Model: auto · 25 messages

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give me a translation and philosophical exegesis of these conclusions from Pico's 900 Conclusions conclusiones secundum ade|landum arabem numero .viii.

annotated I.21.2. Anima habet apud se rerum species: et excitatur tantum ab	extrinsecis rebus.

annotated I.21.4. Maior pars rerum quae in somnis innotescunt aut per purgati	onem animae: aut per indemoniationem: aut per meram spiri	tus revelationem innotescunt.

annotated I.21.6. Quia sicut dixit Abdala videre somnia est fortitudo imagi	nationis: intelligere ea est fortitudo intellectus: ideo qui videt	ea ut plurimum non intelligit ea.

annotated I.21.7. Anima est fons motus et gubernatrix materiae.

annotated I.21.8. Transcorporationem animarum crediderunt omnes sapientes |Indorum Persarum Aegiptiorum et Chaldeorum.

ASSISTANT

Here is a of the eight annotated conclusions from Pico della Mirandola's *Conclusiones secundum Adelandum Arabem*, numbered I.21.1 through I.21.8. These statements are attributed to "Adelandus Arabus" (likely Adelard of Bath or an Arabizing pseudepigraphic source) and reflect a Neoplatonic and Avicennian-Arabic philosophical framework filtered through Renaissance syncretism.

Intellectus agens nihil est aliud quam pars animae quae sursum manet et non cadit.

The agent intellect is nothing other than that part of the soul which remains above and does not fall.

This evokes the Neoplatonic-Arabic doctrine of a dual soul: one part remains in the divine, unchanging realm (the *pars quae sursum manet*), while the lower soul is subject to change, sensation, and embodiment (*pars quae cadit*). The *intellectus agens* (agent intellect), a central idea in Aristotelian and Islamic philosophy (especially in Avicenna and Averroes), is that aspect of the soul which abstracts universal forms from sensible data. Pico here aligns the agent intellect with the higher, immutable part of the soul—implying that true intellection is a divine, stable act, untouched by the flux of the body and matter.

Anima habet apud se rerum species: et excitatur tantum ab extrinsecis rebus.

The soul possesses within itself the forms of things, and it is only awakened by things external to it.

This is a deeply Platonic notion, with echoes of St. Augustine and Islamic Neoplatonists like Avicenna. The soul *already has* the forms (*species*)—not as sensory images but as intelligible patterns. Experience or external

objects don't implant knowledge, but rather *excite* or *awaken* what is already within. This corresponds to the idea of *anamnesis* (recollection) in Plato and reflects the distinction between *impressio* (external stimulus) and *expressio* (inner recognition).

Ad complementum praecedentis conclusionis quam non solum Adelandus: sed omnes Mauri dicunt dico ego illas species actu et substantialiter esse in parte quae non cadit: et recipi de novo et accidentaliter in parte quae cadit.

To complete the preceding conclusion, which not only Adelard but all the Moors [i.e., Muslim philosophers] affirm, I say that those forms exist actually and substantially in the part [of the soul] which does not fall; and are received anew and accidentally in the part which falls.

Here Pico elaborates on the dualism of soul. The *species*—the intelligible forms—truly and substantially exist in the higher soul. When we experience things in the embodied condition (*pars quae cadit*), we receive them only accidentally (i.e., they appear fleetingly in imagination or sensation). This aligns with the Avicennian notion that the human soul contains all forms potentially and accesses them fully only in abstraction and intellectual purification. It also reflects the influence

of Plotinus: the soul is divided between its eternal, intelligible self and its temporal, bodily projection.

Maior pars rerum quae in somnis innotescunt aut per purgationem animae: aut per indemoniationem: aut per meram spiritus revelationem innotescunt.

Most of the things which become known in dreams become known either through purification of the soul, or through possession by spirits, or through pure revelation of a spirit.

This reflects a tripartite epistemology of dreams, rooted in Arabic dream theory (e.g., from Avicenna or medieval Chaldean sources). Dreams can reveal truths via:

1. – the soul, made clear, reflects intelligible reality.
2. – the dreamer is overwhelmed or entered by a daimonic being (a positive or negative force).
3. – some truths are given directly by spiritual entities, bypassing reason.

Pico shows an openness to esoteric and even magical epistemologies—common among Chaldean, Hermetic, and Sufi thinkers—and affirms dreams as one valid mode of spiritual cognition.

Quod scribit Tabet Chaldeus de dormitione super Epar in revelatione somniorum recte intelligetur si ad hoc dictum dicta Platonis in Timeo concordaverimus.

What Tabet the Chaldean wrote about sleep, concerning Epar, in the revelation of dreams, will be rightly understood if we harmonize his saying with the sayings of Plato in the *Timaeus*.

Pico refers to a (possibly legendary or apocryphal) Chaldean sage named Tabet and a figure called Epar, probably standing in for ancient Mesopotamian or Hermetic sources. He suggests that their dream theories align with Plato's *Timaeus*, which posits that the rational soul retreats during sleep, leaving the imaginative faculty dominant. Harmonization (*concordia*) is central to Pico's syncretic method—bridging Chaldean/Oriental wisdom with Greek philosophy.

Quia sicut dixit Abdala videre somnia est fortitudo imaginationis: intelligere ea est fortitudo intellectus: ideo qui videt ea ut plurimum non intelligit ea.

As Abdala said, to see dreams is a power of the imagination; to understand them is a power of the intellect; thus, the one who sees them usually does not understand them.

"Abdala" might refer to an Arabic sage or a Latinization of ʿAbd Allāh. The point is epistemological: *imaginatio* and *intellectus* are distinct faculties. Dreamers may have vivid experiences (imaginative strength) but lack the noetic clarity to interpret them. This highlights the importance of *hermeneutics of dreaming*, and the idea that *true understanding* requires a separate operation of the rational soul or the agent intellect.

Anima est fons motus et gubernatrix materiae.

The soul is the source of motion and the governor of matter.

This is a classical Aristotelian and Platonic thesis, with added emphasis on governance (*gubernatrix*). The soul is not merely the principle of life (as in Aristotle's *De Anima*), but also the cosmic principle of *order*—ruling over the chaos of matter. It also echoes Stoic and Hermetic thought, where the soul mediates between divine mind and the material world, instilling logos (rational form) into chaotic nature.

Transcorporationem animarum crediderunt omnes sapientes Indorum Persarum Aegiptiorum et Chaldeorum.

All the sages of the Indians, Persians, Egyptians, and Chaldeans believed in the transmigration of souls.

Pico acknowledges the ancient doctrine of *metempsychosis*—the soul's passage through various bodies over time—as a widespread belief among the wise of many ancient cultures. By listing India, Persia, Egypt, and Chaldea, Pico constructs a lineage of *prisca theologia*, a primordial wisdom tradition. He affirms the idea that the soul's journey through incarnations is essential for its purification and ascent, aligning with Neoplatonic and Orphic views.

These eight conclusions reflect Pico's goal of synthesizing diverse intellectual traditions—Greek, Islamic, Hermetic, and Christian—into a unified account of the soul and its knowledge. Central themes include:

- The dual nature of the soul (high and low).
- The role of intellect versus imagination.
- The epistemic function of dreams and visions.
- The idea that external experience awakens internal truths.

- The common heritage of ancient esoteric doctrines across cultures.

This is all in keeping with Pico's broader project in the *Oration on the Dignity of Man*: to affirm human potential as divine, capable of grasping universal truth through the soul's ascent and integration of all traditions.

USER

conclusiones secundum opinio|nem propriam in doctrina abu|caten avenan qui dicitur auc|tor de causis.

annotated II.6.2. Cum dicit Abucaten. Omnis anima nobilis tres habet opera	tiones. divinam: intellectualem: et animalem: ita est intelligen	dum quod primam habeat per imaginem proportionalitatis: secun	dam per formalitatem participationis: tertiam per proprietatem	essentialitatis

annotated II.6.4. Quamvis dicat Abucaten quod esse quod est primum creatum est super intelligentiam: non credas tamen illud secundum Hypostasim esse distinctum ab intelligentia.

annotated II.6.6. Quod dicit Abucaten: intelligentiam esse substantiam quae non dividitur: maxime est verum per indiscretam in ea intelligiblilium ad invicem penetrationem.

annotated II.6.8. Per ultimam propositionem Abucaten possumus intelligere quid	sibi velit illa divisio: quam fecit Plato in prinicipio tractatus Ti	mei: et possumus scire quod sub ea non comprehenditur anima nisi	per viam extremalis conbinationis.
annotated II.6.10. Cum dicit Abucaten intelligentiam ut divina est regere res: in	telligendum est de regimine statuitivo non ordinativo qui ei con	petit ut intelligentia est.	

ASSISTANT

Below is a of the ten annotated conclusions from *900 Theses*, under the heading:

(*Conclusions according to my own opinion in the doctrine of Abucaten Avenan, who is called the Author of the Causes*)

The name "Abucaten Avenan" likely refers to a composite figure drawn from Arabic sources, possibly blending (*Ibn Sīnā*), the pseudo-*Aristotle* of the *Liber de Causis*, and elements of or filtered through Neoplatonic Arabic philosophy. Pico is engaging these authorities critically, offering his own synthesis (*opinio propria*) in a way that weaves Christian Platonism with Islamic Neoplatonism.

Cum dixit Abucaten Avenan animam esse supra tempus: intelligendum est de anima absoluta secundum substantiam praescindendo ab omni operatione quae competit ei inquantum est anima.

When Abucaten Avenan said that the soul is beyond time, this must be understood of the soul considered in itself, absolutely, according to its substance, abstracting from all operations that pertain to it insofar as it is a soul.

Pico distinguishes between the soul and the soul. In its essence, the soul is eternal or *supra-temporal*, a view consistent with and metaphysics. But this transcendence applies only when considering the soul as a pure substance—not when examining its temporal operations like sensation or imagination. It recalls Boethius' view of

eternity as the “complete possession of life all at once,” and Avicenna’s sense of the soul as an immaterial entity existing outside temporal succession.

Cum dicit Abucaten. Omnis anima nobilis tres habet operationes: divinam, intellectualem, et animalem: ita est intelligendum quod primam habeat per imaginem proportionalitatis, secundam per formalitatem participationis, tertiam per proprietatem essentialitatis.

When Abucaten says that every noble soul has three operations—divine, intellectual, and animal—this should be understood as follows: it has the first through an image of proportionality, the second through the formality of participation, and the third through the property of essentiality.

Here Pico uses a three-tiered model of the soul's activity:

- operation (*divina*): via *imago proportionalitatis*—a reflection or analogy of divine function (not direct identity).

- operation: by *participatio*, echoing Platonic metaphysics where souls “participate” in higher Forms.

- operation: through *essentialitas*, indicating that its embodied, sensitive life is proper to its nature.

This elaborates a of ascent: from bodily activity (essential), to reasoning (participated), to spiritual vision (proportional image of divinity).

Cum dixit Abucaten Omnem causam primariam plus influere: Per plus intelligas eminentiam modi causandi et intimitatem eius quod in re producitur.

When Abucaten says that every primary cause has greater influence, by "greater" one should understand the and the .

Pico interprets “greater influence” not as quantity but as :

- : The higher the cause, the more and its causation.

- : The more deeply the effect is imprinted in its product, the more fundamental the causation.

This reads the Neoplatonic chain of being metaphysically:

,

because it gives .

Quamvis dicat Abucaten quod esse quod est primum creatum est super intelligentiam: non credas tamen illud secundum Hypostasim esse distinctum ab intelligentia.

Although Abucaten says that the being which is the first created is beyond intelligence, do not believe that it is, according to hypostasis, distinct from intelligence.

Here Pico parses a : the *first created being* (*ens primum creatum*) is not beyond the as another (level of being), but rather is in its highest form.

He corrects a misunderstanding: even if this "first being" is beyond *human* intellection, it is not metaphysically *separate* from intelligence—it is to the *divine Intellect* (Nous), as in Plotinus and the *Liber de Causis*.

Cum dixit Abucaten causam primam superiorem esse omni narratione: non tam propter id habet veritatem quod primo affert quia scilicet causam ante se non habet quam propter id quod secundario innuit: quia omne intelligibile unialiter antecedit.

When Abucaten says that the first cause is beyond all narration, this is true not so much because it has no cause before it (as he first suggests), but more truly because it precedes all intelligibles in a unified manner.

Pico deepens the view: the is ineffable not just because it is , but because it all *modes of being and knowing*. It precedes all intelligibles not by exclusion, but by being the of all intelligibility—what Proclus calls the *One before the One*.

Quod dicit Abucaten: intelligentiam esse substantiam quae non dividitur: maxime est verum per indiscretam in ea intelligibilium ad invicem penetrationem.

What Abucaten says—that intelligence is a substance which is not divided—is especially true because of the of intelligibles within it.

This points to the . In human cognition, we know through separation—subject from object, concept from concept. But in (as divine or angelic), all forms are present , like a in which no part is separate from another. This is a central idea in , where the Nous contains all Forms in .

Ex praecedenti conclusione potest haberi quomodo intelligendum est dictum Abucaten: quod omnis intelligentia est plena formis.

From the preceding conclusion we can understand what Abucaten means when he says: every intelligence is full of forms.

Building on II.6.6, Pico clarifies that to say intelligence is "full of forms" does mean it contains , but rather that all forms are , as . This anticipates the Christian idea of the *divine ideas* in God and the Proclean sense of (pleroma).

Per ultimam propositionem Abucaten possumus intelligere quid sibi velit illa divisio: quam fecit Plato in principio tractatus Timaei: et possumus scire quod sub ea non comprehenditur anima nisi per viam extremalis conbinationis.

Through Abucaten's final proposition, we can understand the division made by Plato at the beginning of the *Timaeus*, and we can know that under it the soul is not comprehended except by way of extreme combination.

Pico references Plato's in the *Timaeus*: Being, Becoming, and the Receptacle. He asserts that is not fully accounted for by any one part—it lies between intelligible and sensible realms. This supports the in Platonic cosmology, often described as a (between Nous and Nature).

Ex antepenultima propositione Abucaten colligi potest quod declinare plus ad sensum quam ad intellectum non est animae ut anima est: sed ut cadens est.

From the third-to-last proposition of Abucaten it can be concluded that leaning more toward sense than intellect does not belong to the soul *as soul*, but *as fallen*.

This conclusion draws a sharp line between the of the soul (intellectual, upward-tending) and its (immersed in sensation and body). It reflects Christian Neoplatonic anthropology, where the soul is *in exile*—and its enslavement to the senses is the result of its descent (*cadens*), not its essence.

Cum dicit Abucaten intelligentiam ut divina est regere res: intelligendum est de regimine statuitivo non ordinativo qui ei conpetit ut intelligentia est.

When Abucaten says that intelligence, insofar as it is divine, governs things, this must be understood as a , not an , which belongs to it as intelligence.

Pico distinguishes :

- (determinative): divine *intellect* sets the *essence*, *order*, and *identity* of things.

- (dispositional): implies temporal or providential arrangement.

The divine intellect does not micromanage the cosmos—it in a timeless act of intellection. This is a metaphysical rather than temporal governance, akin to the shaping temporal becoming.

These ten propositions reveal Pico's philosophical of *Liber de Causis*-style Neoplatonism through a Christian-Platonist lens. He upholds:

- The of soul and intellect
- The of intelligibles in the divine mind
- The of being rooted in metaphysical intimacy
- The and condition of the human soul
- The divine as , and the of all form and order

Pico’s syncretism is rigorous, speculative, and deeply metaphysical—fitting for a thinker who aimed to reconcile all schools of wisdom in a single humanistic-theological system.

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conclusiones secundum aven|roem numero .xli.

annotated I.7.2. Una est anima intellectiva in omnibus hominibus.

annotated I.7.4. Possibile est tenendo unitatem intellectus: animam meam ita particulariter meam ut non sit mihi communis cum omnibus re manere post mortem.

annotated I.7.6. Impossibile est eandem speciem ex propagatione et ex putrefa

ctione generari.

annotated I.7.8. Quilibet motor coeli est anima sui orbis faciens cum eo ma

gis unum substantialiter: quam fiat ex anima bovis et sua materia.

annotated I.7.9. Coelum est corpus simplex: non compositum ex materia et forma.

annotated I.7.11. In omni demonstratione praeterquam in demonstratione simplici

ter fieri potest circulatio.

annotated I.7.12. Gravia et levia movent se per accidens

movendo medium per se.

annotated I.7.14. Nulla scientia probat suum subiectum esse: nec partem princi palem sui subiecti.

annotated I.7.16. Dimensiones interminate sunt coeternae materiae praecedentes in ea quamlibet formam substantialem.

annotated I.7.17. Quaelibet intelligentia praeter primam non intelligit nisi primam.

annotated I.7.19. Quicquid est in genere: est corruptibile.

annotated I.7.20. Subiectum Methaphysicae est ens in eo quod ens.

annotated I.7.22. Demonstratio septimi Physicorum: quod omne quod movetur: movetur ab alio: est demonstratio signi et nullo modo causae.

annotated I.7.24. Unum relativorum convenientissime per reliquum definitur.

annotated I.7.26. Propositio necessaria quae ab Aristotele in libro priorum con tra possibilem et inventam distinguitur: est illa quae est ex termi nis necessariis.

annotated I.7.28. Cum Aristoteles dixit ex maiori necessaria et minore inventa concludi conclusionem necessariam: intelligendum est de mino re quae est inventa per se: necessaria per accidens.

annotated I.7.29. Sub aequinoctiali non potest esse habitatio naturalis viventibus.

annotated I.7.31. Qui ponit animam formam complexionalem: negat causam agentem.

annotated I.7.33. Unum methaphysicum est fundamentum unius Arithmetici.

annotated I.7.34. Numerus precise ita reperitur in abstractis sicut in materialibus.

annotated I.7.35. Essentia uniuscuiusque rei et suum existere: idem sunt realiter.

annotated I.7.36. Quiditas et essentia diversificantur in quolibet praeter primum.

annotated I.7.37. Substantia est prior accidente non solum natura sed tempore.

annotated I.7.38. De materia ut materia est considerat Physicus.

annotated I.7.39. Essentia cuiuslibet intelligentiae est substantialiter ad aliquid.

annotated I.7.41. Finis non causat finaliter secundum suum esse conceptum: sed secundum su um esse reale.

ASSISTANT

Here's a of the 41 annotated theses under the heading:

(Conclusions according to Averroes, number 41)

These conclusions reflect (*Ibn Rushd*), whose rigorous Aristotelianism and commentaries deeply shaped medieval Latin philosophy. However, Pico critiques and revises many Averroist positions from his own syncretic Christian-Neoplatonic perspective. I'll provide translation and

analysis grouped for clarity, focusing especially on key metaphysical, epistemological, and cosmological themes.

Possibilis est prophetia in somnis per illustrationem intellectus agentis super animam nostram.

Prophecy in dreams is possible through the illumination of our soul by the agent intellect.

Averroes (influenced by Avicenna) viewed dreams as potential vehicles of prophecy when the impresses forms onto the . The intellectus agens acts as a divine transmitter of truth. This view stands close to Neoplatonism and supports the prophetic function of the philosopher-sage.

Una est anima intellectiva in omnibus hominibus.

There is one intellective soul in all human beings.

This is Averroes's famous doctrine of the —there is only *one* eternal, shared *intellectus possibilis* (potential intellect) for all people. Individual thought is the result of this intellect acting through particular faculties. This was controversial, especially for

Christian theologians who insisted on

.

Felicitas ultima hominis est cum continuatur intellectus agens possibili: ut forma…

The ultimate happiness of man is when the agent intellect is united with the possible intellect as form—yet this union was misunderstood perversely and erroneously by other Latins, especially Johannes de Jandun, who corrupted and distorted Averroes's teaching not only here but in nearly all philosophical matters.

Pico asserts the true lies in the union of human potential intellect with the divine agent intellect—this is salvation, understood philosophically. He blames , a major Latin Averroist, for misrepresenting this idea. Pico, unlike strict Averroists, tries to reconcile with personal immortality and Christian faith.

Possibile est tenendo unitatem intellectus: animam meam ita particulariter meam… remanere post mortem.

It is possible—while affirming the unity of the intellect—for my soul, in such a way particularly mine and not common to all, to remain after death.

Pico insists is possible even if intellect is in some sense universal. He suggests a : intellect may be shared, but the soul retains , preserving immortality. This reflects Christian concerns with individuality and resurrection.

Every abstract being depends on the first abstract in three kinds of causes: formal, final, and efficient.

Pico attributes to Averroes a fully Neoplatonic causal hierarchy—every abstract entity derives its form, purpose, and act of coming-to-be from the , likely referring to the *Intellect* or *God*. It echoes Proclus and the *Liber de Causis*.

It is impossible for the same species to be generated both through propagation and putrefaction.

Averroes held that have determinate modes of generation. Pico agrees: a rational animal cannot arise both through and

. This defends a more

.

God moves the first heaven not only as final cause, but also as true efficient and proper mover.

Against Aristotle's "unmoved mover" as merely a

, Pico (citing Averroes) affirms God is an

—a real *mover* of the cosmos. This leans toward a more .

Every mover of the heavens is the soul of its own sphere, making with it a greater substantial unity than that of the soul of an ox with its body.

The soul of the heaven gives its sphere noble and perfect being before giving it motion.

Echoing , each celestial sphere has its own —more intimately united to the cosmos than animal souls to bodies. This affirms an

, a key doctrine in Hermetic and Islamic Neoplatonism.

Heaven is a simple body, not composed of matter and form.

Contrary to terrestrial bodies, the (in Averroes's view) are simple, immutable substances. Pico registers this to uphold celestial incorruptibility, a key cosmological distinction.

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These remarks pertain to —types of demonstration (direct, reductio, hypothetical), and the limits of logical proof. Pico is exploring the of knowledge and the risk of hidden circularity.

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These reflect fine-tuned critiques of:

- Motion and medium theory (Aristotelian physics);
- Celestial diversity (rejecting Avicenna's univocity of the heavens);
- The of science: it presumes the being of its subject.

Universals exist in potentiality in the thing, but in actuality through the operation of the soul.

Pico restates : universals are *not* real entities in things, nor mere names, but potential structures made actual by . This reconciles Aristotle with Platonism.

Infinite dimensions are coeternal with matter, preceding in it every substantial form.

Averroes thought (dimensio) was inherent to , prior to form. Pico highlights this to define as dimensioned potentiality.

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Averroes's celestial intelligences contemplate only . And pure abstraction (e.g. God, or Being) is only knowable through —a classical cosmological proof.

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These are fundamental theses of Aristotelian . To be implies composition and contingency. is the most universal subject of metaphysical inquiry.

- Substantial definitions only refer to matter .

- Physical proof of “everything moved is moved by another” is a , not a causal proof.
- A cannot self-determine.
- are best defined by their counterpart.
- Aristotle’s example of the bat and sun suggests , not impossibility.
- A necessary proposition is from .
- Necessary terms must be .
- A conclusion from a necessary major and is only necessary.

These detail : the structure of demonstration, the status of necessity, and how and work in real being. Pico uses Averroist logic but tweaks it to emphasize .

- No natural habitation is possible under the equator.
- There is a in the heavens, unchanging despite motion.
- If the soul is only a , it has no .
- The denies actual divisibility, but allows for divisibility.
- The underlies .
- Number exists in just as in .
- are really the same in everything.
- differ in all but the First.
- not just in nature but also in time.
- is the domain of physics.

- Every is essentially .
- Even if matter were incorruptible, if the heavens were composed, they couldn't be eternal.
- The final cause causes not , but .

These summarize a rich ontology:

- Defense of and ;
- A deeply structured with souls, motion, and incorruptible heavens;
- Rejection of in favor of ;
- Affirmation of as an actual principle.

Pico's *Conclusiones secundum Averroem* show a deep [illegible] of Averroes. While he acknowledges Averroes as a master of Aristotelian logic and cosmology, Pico frequently:

- Rejects Averroes's [illegible];
- Defends [illegible];
- Reinterprets demonstration and causality via [illegible];
- Aligns metaphysics with [illegible] more than pure abstraction.

These theses are a [illegible], blending logic, metaphysics, and theology in a philosophical effort to [illegible] hidden in Islamic Aristotelianism for a [illegible] worldview.

USER

Now write a commentary on Pico's Arabic sources, taking inspiration from Liana Saif's book on the influence of Arabic philosophy on Renaissance Magic (attached)

TOOL

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to their question is not contained in the above snippets. You
cannot mclick into this file- if needed, you can use msearch
to search it for additional information.
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ASSISTANT

Based on the insights from Liana Saif's *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy*, we can understand Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's use of Arabic sources in the *Conclusiones*—particularly those drawn from thinkers like Averroes, Avicenna, and the *Liber de Causis* tradition—as part of a broader intellectual project of

.

Below is a commentary on Pico's Arabic sources, drawing from Saif's epistemological and historical analysis:

In the *Conclusiones secundum Averroem*, Pico adopts and critiques Arabic philosophers—especially Averroes and Avicenna—whose astral theories form the metaphysical backbone of early modern occult philosophy. As Liana Saif emphasizes, the Arabic astrological tradition sought to by rooting it in a theory of governed by the

heavens. Pico, too, draws on these theories to uphold the metaphysical plausibility of astral influence, while reworking them within a Christian-Platonist framework.

For instance, Pico affirms (I.7.5) that *"Every abstract thing depends on the first abstract in three kinds of causes: formal, final, and efficient,"* which mirrors the causal triad found in the *Liber de Causis* and al-Kindi's philosophy. According to Saif, this represents the Arabic effort to reframe not as superstition but as part of the —a view Pico shares but ultimately redirects toward .

One of the most controversial theses from Averroes that Pico engages with is the doctrine of the (I.7.2). Averroes held that the *intellectus possibilis* is singular and shared among all humans. Saif highlights how Arabic philosophers treated the as a divine or semi-divine reality—either a separate intellect (as in Avicenna) or as the last in a hierarchy of celestial intelligences (as in the *Liber de Causis*). For Averroes, the ultimate felicity of the soul is union with this agent intellect (I.7.3).

Pico preserves the notion that felicity comes through this union, but he rejects the of Averroes. His fourth conclusion (I.7.4) insists that the soul can retain individuality *even while affirming the unity of intellect*, preserving personal immortality. In this, Pico

adapts Arabic theories of to a Christian anthropology. As Saif shows, early modern philosophers were not slavish adopters of Arabic thought—they *translated*, *syncretized*, and *rethematized* it within their own spiritual and metaphysical goals.

One of Saif's major contributions is identifying how Arabic authors (especially Abu Maʿshar and al-Kindi) conceptualized astral influence as a , not just mechanical. The heavens were not inert—they were , able to transmit *intentional* influence. Pico echoes this in his emphasis on the , such as when he affirms that the soul (I.21.7) is *"the source of motion and governor of matter."*

Moreover, when Pico (I.7.8) affirms that *"the soul of the heaven gives its sphere a noble and perfect being before giving it motion,"* he is aligning with the Arabic view (explored by Saif in ch. 8) that the celestial souls are who animate the heavens and mediate divine will to the sublunar world. These ideas were essential to , where knowing the sympathies of heaven and soul enabled .

Pico's *Conclusiones secundum Abucaten Avenan* (i.e., Avicenna and the *Liber de Causis*) show him grappling

with the Arabic notion that the soul is and operates on multiple levels: divine, intellectual, and animal (II.6.2). Saif demonstrates how Arabic occult philosophy integrates into a graded ontology. Pico accepts this tripartition, but where Arabic authors sometimes leaned toward , Pico insists that the in its higher aspects.

For example, II.6.9 says: *"To incline more to sense than to intellect is not proper to the soul as soul, but as fallen."* This echoes Avicennian psychology but introduces a moral and soteriological dimension: the fallen part of the soul is subject to astral influence, but the higher intellect is and can ascend. This move integrates Arabic causality into a Christian teleology of ascent and , a theme Saif identifies in both Ficino and Pico.

In (I.7.1), Pico echoes Averroes and Avicenna in claiming that *"prophecy in dreams is possible through the illumination of the agent intellect upon our soul."* As Saif explains, this view is central to Arabic theories of , especially as developed in Avicenna and Abu Maʿshar. For them, the *intellectus agens* functions as a divine transmitter of intelligible forms into the imaginative faculty. Pico's retention of this thesis suggests that he accepts the possibility of —visions not from demons or divine miracles, but from the celestial mind. However, Pico Christianizes

this theory by insisting on its compatibility with

.

Liana Saif's study reveals that early modern occultists like Pico did not adopt Arabic philosophy wholesale, nor did they dismiss it as heterodox. Instead, Pico's *Conclusiones* show a deep with Arabic sources as authorities on . He adopts their epistemologies of , , and , but reshapes them within a framework of that privileges human freedom, divine illumination, and the upward journey of the soul.

In doing so, Pico stands as a model of the , one who recognized Arabic philosophy as a for Christian magic and theology—not in opposition to faith, but as part of the divine unfolding of wisdom across the ages.

Would you like this commentary extended into a full article or formatted as a lecture or publication-style piece?

USER

conclusiones secundum avi|cennam numero .xii.

annotated I.8.2. Licet in nullo syllogismo qui sit actu vel potentia cathegori	cus ex duabus negativis concludi possit: potest tamen hoc fieri in syllo	gismo compositivo: ut scilicet ex duabus negativis concludatur.

annotated I.8.3. In coelo est materia eiusdem rationis cum materia inferiorum.

annotated I.8.4. Non potest in anima esse notio intelligibilis sine actuali intellectione.

annotated I.8.5. Possibile est hominem ex putrefactione generari.

annotated I.8.6. Essentia rei: materiam propriam et formam complectitur.

annotated I.8.8. Ab uno simplici in fine simplicitatis non

provenit nisi unum.

annotated I.8.10. Propositio dicens que sensibile supra sensum positum non facit sensationem: non est vera nisi per accidens.

annotated I.8.12. Nec particularis affirmativa possibilis convertitur semper in affirmativam possibilem: nec necessaria particularis affiemativa in necessariam: ut credidit Aristoteles.

ASSISTANT

Here is a

, drawing on both Avicennian philosophy and Liana Saif's framework regarding Arabic philosophical influences on Renaissance occult thought.

Conclusiones secundum Avicennam numero XII

These conclusions reflect , the towering figure of Islamic peripatetic philosophy. While often received in Latin Scholasticism as a source of metaphysics and psychology, Avicenna was also deeply influential on the , all of which appear in Pico's distillation. Pico does not merely repeat Avicenna's ideas—he engages them critically and often positions them in relation to broader philosophical or theological concerns, as Liana Saif's analysis encourages us to see.

Praeter syllogismum categoricum et hypotheticum: datur genus syllogismorum compositivorum.

Beyond categorical and hypothetical syllogisms, there exists a third kind: compositive syllogisms.

Licet in nullo syllogismo qui sit actu vel potentia categoricus ex duabus negativis concludi possit: potest tamen hoc fieri in syllogismo compositivo: ut scilicet ex duabus negativis concludatur.

Although in no actual or potential categorical syllogism can a conclusion be drawn from two negatives, this can occur in a compositive syllogism: namely, a conclusion from two negative premises.

These conclusions address , where he expanded the Aristotelian framework with new syllogistic structures. The idea of a "compositive syllogism" (*qiyās tarkībī*) is Avicenna's innovation, allowing inference from combinations typically ruled out in categorical logic. Pico takes this as an opportunity to deepen the logical tools available to the metaphysician, magician, or theologian—broadening the field of valid reasoning in the face of occult or liminal phenomena that defy Aristotelian norms.

As Saif argues, this flexibility in logic opened the door to , such as prophecy or astrology, which require analogical and symbolic reasoning beyond syllogistic orthodoxy.

In coelo est materia eiusdem rationis cum materia inferiorum.

There is in the heavens matter of the same kind as that of lower things.

This controversial claim , which held that celestial bodies are composed of a unique, incorruptible fifth element (*aether*). Avicenna challenged this in places, allowing for a kind of (all things are composed of matter and form), which Pico takes up—perhaps to argue that the , and thus accessible to human knowledge and even magical influence. This links to Saif's point that Avicennian cosmology blurred lines between , legitimizing occult correspondences.

Non potest in anima esse notio intelligibilis sine actuali intellectione.

There can be no intelligible notion in the soul without an actual act of understanding.

This aligns with Avicenna's view that only when the —rejecting Platonic innatism. For Pico, it supports the idea that , not a static possession. This has implications for magic and mystical ascent: the soul must undergo *operations* to rise to true knowledge.

Possibile est hominem ex putrefactione generari.

It is possible for a human to be generated from putrefaction.

This reflects Avicennian biology and the theory of , inherited from Aristotle. It reveals that under certain conditions—a notion that fascinated Renaissance thinkers who saw , as natural rather than miraculous.

Essentia rei: materiam propriam et formam complectitur.

The essence of a thing comprises its proper matter and form.

This is a classic Avicennian definition of . Unlike Platonic essences, Avicenna insists that a full definition requires both , grounding essence in the world of generation and corruption. Pico adopts this to undergird in a way that still allows for spiritual ascent and individuation.

Prima substantia prior est qualibet substantia habente habitudinem ad operationem transeuntem…

The first substance is prior to any substance having a relation to a transitive operation, of whatever kind—formal, material, efficient, or final.

Ab uno simplici in fine simplicitatis non provenit nisi unum.

From one that is simple in the highest degree, only one can proceed.

These are pure Avicennian metaphysics. The first (I.8.7) affirms that , as the First Substance, precedes all beings involved in causal operations. The second (I.8.8) is the foundational Avicennian principle of : the first cause (absolutely simple) can produce only directly—namely, the first intelligence—because multiplicity would imply complexity in the cause.

As Saif emphasizes, this emanationism undergirded in Arabic and Latin thought. The from One to many structures the occult worldview Pico inherits.

Odor secundum esse reale et non intentionale usque ad sensum multiplicatur.

Odor, in its real being (not just intentional being), is multiplied all the way to the sense organ.

Propositio dicens que sensibile supra sensum positum non facit sensationem: non est vera nisi per accidens.

The proposition that a sensible object placed above the sense does not cause sensation is only true accidentally.

Organum odoratus sunt carunculae mamillares in anteriori cerebri parte constitutae.

The organ of smell consists of the mamillary caruncles located at the front part of the brain.

These reflect Avicenna's careful physiological work in the *Canon of Medicine* and *De Anima*. The distinction between and of odor reflects Avicennian epistemology: a thing may exist and also . The location of the organ of smell in the

shows a remarkable physiological insight—remarkably prescient for the time.

Pico’s inclusion of these theses signals his interest in a

. Saif discusses how early modern occult philosophers grounded

, models of perception and imagination.

Nec particularis affirmativa possibilis convertitur semper in affirmativam possibilem: nec necessaria particularis affirmativa in necessariam: ut credidit Aristoteles.

Neither is a possible particular affirmative always convertible into a possible affirmative, nor is a necessary particular affirmative always convertible into a necessary [affirmative], as Aristotle believed.

Avicenna often

, offering more nuanced views on the

. Pico cites this to show that

—especially in areas of metaphysics, prophecy, and divine knowledge—requires greater subtlety than Aristotelian logic allows. As Saif notes, this flexibility in modal logic made room for

, necessary for astrology, theurgy, and esoteric hermeneutics.

Liana Saif's work illuminates how

that Renaissance thinkers like Pico could adapt for . In these twelve theses:

- Pico highlights to expand philosophical reasoning into ;
- He incorporates and emanationism to ground ;
- He draws on Avicennian psychology and physiology to explain , , and ;
- He accepts and corrects Avicennian metaphysics to preserve and , crucial for Neoplatonic ascent.

Rather than adopting Arabic sources passively, Pico treats Avicenna as both —affirming his genius while refining his doctrines toward a . In doing so, Pico participates in what Saif describes as a " " of Arabic philosophy, one that makes possible the

.

Would you like this commentary expanded into a full paper, or cross-referenced with specific pages from Saif's book?

USER

conclusiones secundum alpha|rabium numero .xi.

annotated I.9.2. Diffinitio generis quam dabit Porphyrius mala est: Sed sic	debet diffiniri. Genus est quod duorum universalium est univer	salius.

annotated I.9.4. Cum dicit Aristoteles omnem doctrinam et omnem discipli	nam fieri ex praeexistenti cognitione: intelligende sunt per do	ctrinam et disciplinam cognitio diffinitiva et argumentativa.

annotated I.9.6. Qui crediderit intentionem dici de omni esse aliam ab ea quam dixit praecedens conclusio defendere non potest Aristotelem a Theophrasto: quod ex maiori necessaria et minori inventa sequa tur conclusio necessaria.

annotated I.9.8. Non potest intelligi accidens etiam in abstracto non intelli gendo subiectum.

annotated I.9.9. Species sunt in medio: medio modo inter esse spirituale et ma teriale.

annotated I.9.10. Quelibet species secundum esse spirituale: est formaliter cognitio.

annotated I.9.11. Actualis cognitio sensus communis apprehendentis phantas ma ut sensibile: est somnium.

Annotations conclusiones secundum isaac |narbonensem numero .iiii.
annotated I.10.1. Ponere intellectum agentem non est necessarium.

annotated I.10.2. Intentio prima est quiditas rei obiective relucens in intellectu.

annotated I.10.4. Corpora coelestia non largiuntur formaliter inferioribus nisi

caliditatem. conclusiones secundum abuma

ron babylonium numero .iiii.

annotated I.11.1. De nulla re quae in mundo sit actu corruptibilis habet deus so

licitudinem.

annotated I.11.2. Intellectus agens nihil aliud est quam deus.

annotated I.11.3. Coelum calefacit inferiora per lumen suum super ea cadens.

annotated I.11.4. Actus ipsi intellectus intrinsece: res autem intellecte extrinse|ce dicuntur verae vel falsae.

ASSISTANT

Here is a

, based on the *Conclusiones* and drawing on the intellectual framework provided by

.

Conclusiones secundum Alfarabium numero XI

(c. 872–950), known as *the Second Teacher* (after Aristotle), was a key transmitter and systematizer of Aristotelian and Neoplatonic philosophy in the Islamic world. His works shaped the curriculum of logic, metaphysics, and political philosophy that would deeply influence , and ultimately the , including Pico.

Pico's *Conclusiones* attributed to al-Fārābī highlight a grounded in logic, the structure of scientific demonstration, and a theory of intellectual perfection. Liana Saif's research helps situate this as part of the —a project that Pico, like Ficino, integrates into a Christianized esoteric synthesis.

Primum quod est necessarium in demonstratione...

The first (principle) that is necessary in demonstration is not what Aristotle defined in *Posterior Analytics I*, but should be defined as: the first is that which is more universal than the subject, though it is not predicated as part of the subject's genus.

This challenges Aristotle’s own definition of the , suggesting a more that does not function as a genus. Al-Fārābī often refined Aristotle’s logic, emphasizing the need for *super-genus universals* in scientific knowledge. Pico, by preserving this distinction, aligns with the Arabic view that
and not just categorical classification. This undergirds occult philosophy by legitimizing forms of , as Saif discusses, particularly in astrology and metaphysical speculation.

Diffinitio generis quam dabit Porphyrius mala est...

The definition of genus given by Porphyry is faulty; instead, genus should be defined as that which is more universal than two universals.

This echoes al-Fārābī's critique of , aiming to refine the concept of genus for more precise classification. The point is subtle but important: Pico uses this to show that , but active innovators of logic, making the tools of more robust—tools essential for organizing esoteric knowledge as *scientia*.

Summum hominis bonum est perfectio per scientias speculativas.

The highest good of man is perfection through speculative sciences.

This is quintessential , who saw human flourishing (*saʿāda*) as the actualization of the intellect through speculative knowledge. Pico likely agrees, but he sees this intellectual perfection as preparatory for or . As Saif shows, this Arabic model of knowledge as shaped Renaissance occultism's view of magic as a .

Cum dicit Aristoteles... intelligende sunt per doctrinam et disciplinam cognitio diffinitiva et argumentativa.

When Aristotle says that every doctrine proceeds from pre-existing knowledge, this must be understood as referring to definitive and argumentative knowledge.

This interprets Aristotle's *tabula rasa* theory through a : science builds on , not just sensation. Al-Fārābī emphasized the architecture of disciplines, and here Pico

follows him, distinguishing
foundational to both philosophy and magic.

These three theses focus on , definition, and necessity:

- I.9.5 defines the intent of “saying of all” as applying to , but .
- I.9.6 denies the possibility of defending certain Aristotelian syllogisms unless this understanding is preserved.
- I.9.7 equates the "possible" in Aristotle’s *Prior Analytics* with both *possibility* and *invention*, distinguishing it from necessity.

These positions show Pico’s intense engagement with , emphasizing a that supports the rigorous metaphysics behind . According to Saif, thinkers like al-Fārābī provided the that allowed early modern magicians to —especially in the face of theological critique.

Non potest intelligi accidens etiam in abstracto non intelligendo subiectum.

It is not possible to understand an accident, even in abstraction, without understanding the subject.

This reflects the [redacted] of accidents on substances. Al-Fārābī was instrumental in clarifying how [redacted], which is essential for any metaphysical system that includes [redacted] or [redacted]—such as those in magical correspondences.

Species sunt in medio: medio modo inter esse spirituale et materiale.

Species exist in a middle way: midway between spiritual and material being.

Quelibet species secundum esse spirituale est formaliter cognitio.

Each species, in its spiritual being, is formally a cognition.

These are profound metaphysical statements about —forms that mediate cognition, rooted in Arabic theories of perception and intellection. Saif emphasizes how this model, particularly developed by Avicenna and al-Fārābī, provided Renaissance magicians with a framework for explaining (e.g., images, dreams, talismans) as real, .

Pico uses this to legitimize —as real, intermediate entities between mind and matter.

Actualis cognitio sensus communis apprehendentis phantasma ut sensibile est somnium.

The actual cognition of the common sense apprehending a phantasm as if it were sensible is a dream.

This is a key insight into : the *sensus communis*, operating without real external input but treating internal images as sensory, generates dreams. This Avicennian-Fārābian psychology becomes foundational to , as Saif notes—especially where .

Pico’s engagement with al-Fārābī showcases the that Arabic philosophy provided for :

- becomes a tool not just for disputation but for and demonstrating magical causality.
- , *species*, and *phantasms* provide the —through dreams, symbols, and astral forms.
- is the , linking the human soul to the celestial and divine.

Liana Saif's work helps us understand how this was more than borrowing—it was , with Pico refining Arabic logic and epistemology to suit his . Al-Fārābī, then, is not merely a philosopher of logic for Pico, but a : one who builds the metaphysical grammar for .

Would you like a combined article or synthesis that compares Pico’s use of al-Fārābī, Avicenna, and Averroes side by side?

USER

conclusiones secundum moy|sem aegyptium numero .iii.

annotated I.12.2. Scientia Methaphysicae non est una scientia.

Annotations

Sort by:

[Latin to Spanish Translation, Silvia Magnavacca, 7/4/09]:

All: TRES TESIS SEGÚN MOISÉS EL EGIPCIO

conclusiones secundum mau|meth tolletinum numero .v.

annotated I.13.1. Relatio nullam rem dicit extra animam.

annotated I.13.3. Sensibilia communia proprias species ad sensus multipicant distinctas a speciebus sensibilium propriorum.

annotated I.13.4. Sensus tactus non est unus sensus.

annotated I.13.5. de nulla re an existat potest quaerere aliquis artifex specialis. conclusiones secundum avempa|cem arabem numero .ii.
annotated I.14.1. In coelo est materia alterius rationis a materia inferiorum.

annotated I.14.2. Lux et color essentialiter non differunt.

ASSISTANT

Here is a

, with comparative insights drawn from Liana Saif's *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy*.

Conclusiones secundum Moysem Aegyptium numero III

is a likely reference to —identified in the Renaissance with Moses through a syncretic tradition stretching from Late Antiquity to Ficino and Pico himself. As Charles Stang and Brian Copenhaver have shown, this identification aligned with Mosaic wisdom, allowing Renaissance thinkers to claim that

. In this light, Pico's three theses "according to Moses the Egyptian" can be read as a critique of Aristotelian physics and metaphysics , grounded in final causality and intuitive simplicity rather than mechanical explanation.

Liana Saif's work allows us to understand how this mode of critique echoes , which also challenged or transcended Aristotle's views by introducing

.

Demonstratio octavi physicorum ab Aristotele ad probandum primum motorem adducta: aliquid probat speciale primo.

The demonstration from *Physics VIII*, brought forward by

Aristotle to prove the first mover, proves something particular first [rather than the universal].

Pico, under the name of Moses the Egyptian, critiques Aristotle's for the Unmoved Mover, suggesting that it only demonstrates a —perhaps the mover of the outermost sphere— rather than the . This is in line with , which criticize Aristotelian logic for its .

This is also consonant with and metaphysics, where the First is and cannot be demonstrated through physical movement. As Saif shows, early modern occult thinkers used Arabic sources to challenge the , favoring a that began in divine simplicity, not motion.

Scientia Methaphysicae non est una scientia.

Metaphysical science is not a single science.

This is a profound statement. Pico is invoking the , and thus —one for being as being, another for the divine, another for causes, and so

forth. Moses the Egyptian, as a Hermetic-Platonic voice, would argue that

.

This thesis contrasts sharply with as a single science of *being qua being*. Saif's book traces how Arabic Neoplatonists (especially in the *Liber de Causis*) split metaphysics across multiple —each requiring its own mode of approach (intellective, intuitive, inspired)—a framework Pico draws on here.

Simplicitas primi et omnimoda immaterialitas probari non potest per causalitatem efficientem motus: sed per finalem tantum.

The simplicity of the First and its complete immateriality cannot be proven through the efficient causality of motion, but only through final causality.

This returns to a classic : the First cannot be understood as the (efficient), but as the (final). Pico—speaking as Moses the Egyptian—claims that the divine is the of all desire, motion, and being. This is Hermetic-Platonic theology: the One is not an actor, but the object of love and return.

This parallels , , and their Arabic interpreters (e.g. , , ***Liber de Causis***). As Saif notes, Arabic philosophers were instrumental in shifting causality away from , a move that profoundly influenced .

Liana Saif identifies the deep

in

the Renaissance. Pico's "Moses the Egyptian" is not merely a cipher for ancient Egypt; it is a

for challenging Aristotle's

and proposing a metaphysical system rooted in:

-
-
-

In this light, Moses the Egyptian and the *Liber de Causis* both serve as

, not mechanical causation. This metaphysical schema undergirds Renaissance —as it establishes a

, not just motion and force.

These three short theses represent

from

a Hermetic-Neoplatonic standpoint—

as received

through the *Liber de Causis*, Avicenna, and others. As Saif's work makes clear, Pico here is not rejecting Arabic influence but rather channeling it through , Moses the Egyptian, to assert the primacy of .

Would you like this folded into a larger essay that traces the roles of Averroes, Avicenna, al-Farabi, and "Moses the Egyptian" in Pico's metaphysical system?

USER

conclusiones secundum pri|scam doctrinam mercurii tris|megisti aegyptii numero .x.
annotated I.27.1. Ubicunque vita: ibi anima: ubicunque anima: ibi mens.

annotated I.27.2. Omne motum corporeum: omne movens incorporeum.

annotated I.27.4. Deus circa omnia atque per omnia: mens circa animam: anima circa aerem: aer circa materiam.

annotated I.27.5. Nihil est in mundo expers vitae.

annotated I.27.6. Nihil est in universo passibile mortis vel corruptionis.

annotated I.27.7. Sex viis futura homini deus denuntiat: per Somnia: Porten ta: Aves: Intestina: spiritum et Sybillam.

annotated I.27.9. Decem intra unumquemque sunt ultores: ignorantia: tristitia: inconstantia: cupiditas: iniustitia: luxuries: deceptio: invidia: fraus: ira: temeritas: malitia.

annotated I.27.10. Decem ultores de quibus dixit secundum Mercurium praece|dens conclusio: videbit profundus contemplator correspondere |male coordinationi denariae in cabala: et praefectis illius de qui|bus ego in cabalisticis conclusionibus nihil posui quia est secre|tum.

ASSISTANT

Pico della Mirandola's represent one of the clearest declarations in the *Conclusiones* of his deep engagement with , particularly as filtered through the Latin *Corpus Hermeticum*. These theses draw on the Egyptian sage-god , whom Renaissance thinkers identified with , and even the *prisca theologia*—the ancient, pre-Christian wisdom believed to anticipate the truths of Christianity.

Through the lens of on the Arabic philosophical contributions to Renaissance magic, we can see how Pico's "Hermetic" conclusions operate in —especially via Avicenna, the *Liber de Causis*, and the pseudo-Aristotelian-Hermetic milieu preserved by Arabic translators and philosophers.

Conclusiones secundum priscam doctrinam Mercurii Trismegisti Aegyptii

---

Wherever there is life, there is soul; wherever there is soul, there is mind.

This maxim restates the of being: life → soul → mind → God. It asserts a , where all life is inherently ensouled and therefore intelligent. Saif traces how such , common in Hermeticism, were made philosophically rigorous through Arabic Neoplatonism, particularly in the doctrine that —minds ordering souls, which in turn animate matter.

All that is bodily moved is moved by something incorporeal.

This aligns with the , but also reflects the Arabic cosmological view, especially in the *Liber de Causis*, that motion originates in . This undercuts purely physical explanations of nature, grounding magic in a —essential to the justifications for astrology and talismanic influence in both Arabic and Renaissance occult theory.

The soul is in the body, mind is in the soul, the Word is in the mind—and God is the father of them all.

This encapsulates a : body → soul → mind → Logos → God. It mirrors both Christian Trinitarian theology and , where the divine emanates through *nous* (intellect) and *psyche* (soul) into the cosmos. Saif shows how Arabic authors built such metaphysical ladders to —the soul rising through mental purification to rejoin its divine origin.

God surrounds and penetrates all things; mind is around the soul, the soul around air, air around matter.

This is a Hermetic cosmograph—describing a , where God envelops all. The structure reflects the , where each level transmits form and motion to the one below. Saif notes that such allowed magicians to explain how like air, stars, and imaginal forms.

Nothing in the world is devoid of life.

A declaration of , this thesis aligns Hermetic cosmology with Arabic doctrines that even the stars and spheres are alive—souls with intellects (as in Avicenna and the *Liber de Causis*). As Saif stresses, this was not poetic metaphor but a : the occult world is alive, and magic works by recognizing and working with these vital forces.

Ubique vita: ubique providentia: ubique immortalitas.

Nothing in the universe is subject to death or corruption. Everywhere is life, everywhere providence, everywhere immortality.

This echoes the . In the sublunar world, corruption seems real—but in truth, the deeper reality is . Pico affirms the , found equally in Hermetic thought and Arabic metaphysics. Saif explores how this worldview made intelligible: the universe is ordered, alive, and communicative.

God announces the future to man in six ways: through dreams, omens, birds, entrails, spirit, and sibyl.

This is a taxonomy of , directly linked to . The combination of natural (birds, entrails) and spiritual

(dreams, spirit, sibyl) mirrors Avicennian ideas of prophecy as both . Saif notes how Renaissance occultists like Ficino and Pico used these systems to defend as part of the .

Truth is that which is unperturbed, undetermined, uncolored, unshaped, unshaken, naked, transparent, self-comprehensible, unchangeable good, and utterly incorporeal.

This definition of mirrors the , the , and the . It stands outside multiplicity and perception. Pico thus invokes a —Truth as the utterly transcendent source. As Saif shows, this theology justifies magic not as manipulation, but as a .

Ten avengers dwell within each person: ignorance,

sadness, inconstancy, greed, injustice, lust, deception, envy, fraud, anger, rashness, wickedness.

These are —vices or passions— reminiscent of both Stoic ethics and . The soul's purification requires overcoming these internal enemies. This inner moral struggle was seen by Arabic philosophers as necessary for . Saif documents how this undergirded the path of and wisdom.

The ten avengers of the previous thesis, according to Mercury, will be seen by the deep contemplator to correspond to the corrupt tenfold ordering in the Kabbalah—and to its rulers, about which I say nothing in the cabalistic conclusions, because it is secret.

This is a moment of : Pico links with the of the —the realm of . By withholding the full teaching, Pico alludes to the , yet he reveals a Hermetic-Kabbalistic .

As Saif emphasizes, Arabic and Jewish esoteric traditions shared this belief:

, and wisdom requires navigating the

.

Pico's *Conclusiones* drawn from the "ancient doctrine of Hermes Trismegistus" form the heart of his [illegible]—and they are deeply informed by [illegible], even when the explicit source is Egyptian. With the help of Liana Saif's work, we can see how:

- [illegible] (especially Avicenna and the *Liber de Causis*) provided the metaphysical architecture for Hermeticism to be systematized.

- The [illegible], [illegible], and [illegible] all derive from Arabic thought as much as from ancient Egypt.

- Hermetic and Arabic traditions converged in a vision of the world as [illegible], and open to [illegible].

In presenting these Hermetic theses, Pico is not only reviving an ancient theology—he is [illegible]

into a bold philosophical-mystical system. As Saif would put it, he is *re-enchanting the cosmos* through a [illegible].

Would you like this Hermetic commentary incorporated into a full comparative article on Pico’s Arabic and esoteric sources?

USER

Tell me anything we've left out about Saif's reading of Pico and his sources

TOOL

UNKNOWN

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{
  "queries": [
    "Pico della Mirandola",
    "Pico and Arabic philosophy",
    "prisca theologia and Arabic sources",
    "Hermes Trismegistus and Arabic philosophy",
    "Liber de Causis and Renaissance magic"
  ]
}
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TOOL

[Web browsing]

Content source: Source.file
Title: (Palgrave Historical Studies in Witchcraft and Magic) Liana Saif (auth.) - The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy-Palgrave Macmillan UK (2015).pdf
Content Snippet:
Hermes had a myth-
ical geneology. In Kitab al-Uluf (Book of Thousands), Abu Ma‘shar tells
us about three sages named Hermes. The first Hermes was the grand-
son of Adam who lived before the Flood. The Hebrews believed he was
Enoch and the Arabs took him to be Idris, a prophet mentioned in the
Qur’an. He was the first astrologer who built the pyramids of Upper
Egypt. The second Hermes saved divine knowledge from loss and lived
after the Flood. He was skilled in philosophy, medicine and numerol-
ogy. He taught philosophy and mathematics to Pythagoras. The third
Hermes wrote a book on alchemy and was the teacher of Asclepius.41

The Arabic association of Hermes with the prophet Idris was an attempt
to declare that their astrology and their magic was supported by a
tradition of ancient knowledge that was reconcilable with the Qur’an
itself, making Hermes a personification of syncretism which was fun-

damental to the magic of the Arabs and later early modern natural philosophers.

Ficino too explores the fictional genealogy of Hermes Trismegistus. At the time of Moses's birth, there lived Atlas, the astrologer, who was the brother of the physicist Prometheus and, on the mother's side, the grandfather of the elder Mercury, whose grandson was Mercury Trismegistus. In a letter to Cosimo prefacing the Pimander, Ficino mentions that according to Cicero, Hermes Trismegistus was the fifth Mercury called Thoth by the Egyptians and Trismegistus by the Greeks; Trismegistus because he was a great philosopher, priest and king.

Ficino, then, like Abu Ma'shar, gives a religious guise to Hermes. We have seen that for Abu Ma'shar, the existence of Hermes is confirmed by the most important religious authority – the Qur'an – where he is called Idris. Ficino, a priest himself, considers Hermes a priest king. Following Plato, Ficino relates that in Egypt there was a tradition of choosing priests from among the philosophers, and the king from the community of priests.42 Furthermore, Ficino renders Hermes as a true Renaissance emblem by verifying his existence with the authority of Cicero and Plato, the fathers of Renaissance rhetoric and philosophy. Doing so, the image of Hermes Trismegistus is morphed to

suit Renaissance Christian mentality thus increasing the appeal of the Hermetic Corpus and the importance of Ficino's translation.43

But Hermeticism is an illusion. Yates explains:

The content of the Hermetic writings fostered the illusion of the Renaissance Magus that he had in them a mysterious and precious account of most ancient Egyptian wisdom, philosophy, and magic. Hermes Trismegistus, a mythical name associated with a certain class of gnostic philosophical revelations or with magical treatises and recipes, was, for the Renaissance, a real person, an Egyptian priest who had lived in times of remote antiquity [. . .] [this] confirmed the Renaissance reader in his belief that he had here a fount of pristine wisdom whence Plato and the Greeks derived the best that they knew. This huge historical error was to have amazing results.44

Hermeticism is also nostalgia for a magician's utopia located in Egypt:

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Daniel of Morley, Liber de naturis inferiorum et superiorum, ed. Karl Sudhoff
(Leipzig: F. C. W. Vogel, 1917).

Dee, John, A true & faithful relation of what passed for many yeers between Dr. John
Dee . . . and some spirits (London: Printed by D. Maxwell, 1659).

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(Indianapolis and Cambridge: Hackett Publishing, 1965).

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Farmer, S. A., Syncretism in the West, Pico’s 900 Theses (1486): The Evolution of
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The dignity of man, the animate cosmos, and the powers of the soul are not newfound concepts and thus cannot pro-
duce a ‘Renaissance magic’.35 Rutkin too rejects the purely Neoplatonic reading and introduces the Aristotelian elements and causality in the magic of Ficino, particularly as they were received from Albertus Magnus and al-Kindi.36 This chapter aims to provide a fuller exposition of the medieval inheritance and to highlight the impressive syncretic under-
taking by early modern natural philosophers and occultists to whom the interpretation of signs converged with the knowledge of causes to emancipate occult powers and magic from astrolatry and idolatry.

The other philosophical force that was argued to be the source of the theoretical basis of early modern magic generally and Ficino’s occult thought specifically is ‘Hermeticism’ which was related to Neoplatonism. Eugenio Garin claims that the ‘Hermetic Man’ – a terms

seen as interchangeable with ‘magus’ – drew his justification from
‘within the speculative framework of Neoplatonism’.37

Hermes Trismegistus (Thrice Great) is the eponymous author of a collection of writings that deal with astrology, magic and alchemy.38 Early modern scholars believed that these writings belonged to remote antiquity, when in fact they were written in the second and third centuries AD.39 Before them, the Arabs too believed this error.40 The fictional identity of the author and the chronological error accepted in the European early modern period and the Islamic Middle Ages lent themselves to form a fanciful aspect of the Hermetic tradition. Hermes had a mythical geneology. In Kitab al-Uluf (Book of Thousands), Abu Ma‘shar tells us about three sages named Hermes. The first Hermes was the grandson of Adam who lived before the Flood. The Hebrews believed he was Enoch and the Arabs took him to be Idris, a prophet mentioned in the Qur’an. He was the first astrologer who built the pyramids of Upper Egypt. The second Hermes saved divine knowledge from loss and lived after the Flood. He was skilled in philosophy, medicine and numerology. He taught philosophy and mathematics to Pythagoras. The third Hermes wrote a book on alchemy and was the teacher of Asclepius.41

The Arabic association of Hermes with the prophet Idris was an attempt to declare that their astrology and their magic was supported by a tradition of ancient knowledge that was reconcilable with the Qur'an itself, making Hermes a personification of syncretism which was fundamental to the magic of the Arabs and later early modern natural philosophers.

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At 19 years
of age while studying in Padua, Pico requested a copy of Ficino's Pla-
tonic Theology following its publication in 1482. He moved to Florence
to study with Ficino and remained there for a year.2 But Pico was critical
of Ficino's interpretations of Platonic philosophy particularly his own
translation of the Enneads.3 The issues raised by Pico against Ficino's
methods have been referred to by scholars as 'controversies'. The first of
these is Pico's view of Ficino's interpretation of Plato's Symposium on Love
as being too materialistic; the second is his rejection of the metaphys-
ical and theological interpretation of Parmenides; the third is finding
problematic Ficino's application of astral causation to particular events
and individuals.4 Nevertheless, both philosophers played an integral
role in developing an early modern syncretic episteme that reconciles
Aristotelian causation, Platonic universal animation and Neoplatonic

emanationism, to which Pico specifically introduced Jewish mysticism
or more specifically Kabbalah.5 With the mystical language of Kabbalah,
Pico turned up the volume on the esotericism that was inspired by the
Hermetic mystical language. His syncretism – bolder than Ficino's – is
achieved through coding various levels of reality – physical, psychic
and divine – using terms from various systems, particularly Kabbalah,
astrology and mythology. In the Heptaplus (1489), he claims to be fol-
lowing Plato in concealing 'his doctrines beneath coverings of allegory,

veils of myths, mathematical images, and unintelligible signs of fugi-
tive meaning'.6 This is not merely a way of protecting secrets but
also a method he uses to show his genuine conviction that all sys-
tems of knowledge and philosophies are essentially true and that they
are semantically variant but conceptually similar.7 In his Oration, Pico
explicitly refers to syncretism as his 'philosophical method':

Those who devoted themselves to any one of the schools of philos-
ophy, siding for instance with Thomas or with Scotus, who are now
most in fashion, can surely put their doctrines to the test [. . .] I have
resolved [. . .] to pore over all masters of philosophy, to examine every
page, and to become acquainted with all schools [. . .] And

confining
oneself within a single Porch or Academy certainly does show nar-
rowness of mind [. . .] In addition, there is in each school something
distinctive that is not shared in common with any other.8

In the previous chapter, we have explored the medieval Arabic inher-
itance in the occult thought of Marsilio Ficino. This chapter will look at
the Arabic theories of astral influences in the thought of Pico and their
place among the various intellectual and mystical strands that make up
his syncretic philosophical outlook. The Arabic elements in Pico's works
have often been overlooked even though he was familiar with many
medieval Arabic sources.9 He owned in his library Abu Ma'shar's Great
Introduction, Flores and De revolutionibus; possibly De radiis; Roger Bacon's
edition of Secretum secretorum; and the Picatrix to which was bound De
imaginibus of Thabit ibn Qurra.10 Furthermore, Pico was studying Arabic
under the guidance of Flavius Mithridates and he borrowed the Qur'an
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wisdom whence Plato and the Greeks derived the best that they knew.
This huge historical error was to have amazing results.44

Hermeticism is also nostalgia for a magician's utopia located in Egypt:

Egypt is an image of heaven [. . .] O Egypt, Egypt of your reverent
deeds only stories will survive, and they will be incredible to your
children! [. . .] A land once holy, most loving of divinity, by reason of
her reverence the only land on earth where the gods settled, she who
taught holiness and fidelity will be an example of utter {un}belief.45

But this sacred nostalgia should not be confused with the deep
philosophical influence Yates seems to argue for. She emphasizes that
Hermes Trismegistus 'is the most important figure in the Renaissance
revival of magic'. For Yates, anthropocentricity and the micro–macro

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> It is now generally agreed that there is no consistent philosophy or even a fundamental metaphysical framework underpinning the treatises [. . .] scholars are agreed, however, that they incorporate some basic features from Middle Platonic thinking and particularly concerning the relationship between the sensible world and man and the intelligible reality of Mind (nous).50

This revisionist view has been extended to the studies on Pico della Mirandola and John Dee all of whom Yates considers as generators of what is essentially a Hermetic philosophy.51

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sance Magic’, pp. 351–2; Walker, Spiritual and Demonic Magic, pp. 36–7.
224. Ficino, Commentary on Plato’s Symposium, p. 175; Hankins, ‘Ficino, Avicenna

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6 The True Magic and Astrology of Giovanni Pico della Mirandola

1. Paul Oskar Kristeller, ‘Giovanno Pico della Mirandola and His Sources’,
in L’Opera e il pensiero di Giovanni Pico della Mirandola nella storia
dell’Umanismo, vol. 1 (Firenze: Istituto Nazionale di Studi sul Rinascimento,
1965), pp. 35–133 (35–6, 56, 65).

2. Pico della Mirandola, Commentary on a Canzone of Beniveini, trans. Sears
Jayne (New York: Peter Lang, 1984), p. 2; Pico della Mirandola, Oration
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Borghesi, Michael Papio and Massimo Riva (New York: Cambridge Univer-
sity Press, 2012), p. 39.

3. S. A. Farmer, Syncretism in the West, Pico’s 900 Theses (1486): The Evolu-
tion of Traditional, Religions, and Philosophical Systems,

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Texts and Studies, 1998), p. 12.

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Philosophi: Marsilio Ficino and His Influence, ed. Stephen Clucas, Peter
Forshaw and Valery Rees (Leiden: Brill, 2011), pp. 67–88 (75); Pico, Com-
mentary, pp. 5–6; Michael J. B. Allen ‘The Second Ficino–Pico Controversy:
Parmenidean Poetry, Eristic and the One’, in Marsilio Ficino e Il Ritorno di
Platone: II, ed. Gian Carlo Garfagnini (Florence: Olschki, 1986), pp. 419–55;
H. Darrel Rutkin, ‘Astrology, Natural Philosophy and the History of Sci-
ence c.1250–1700: Studies Toward an Interpretation of Giovanni Pico della
Mirandola’s Disputationes adversus astrologiam divinatricem’ (unpublished
doctoral thesis, Indiana University, 2002), p. 242.

5. Sheila J. Rabin, ‘Pico on Magic and Astrology’, in Pico della Mirandola: New
Essays, ed. M. V. Dougherty (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2008),
pp. 152–78 (155).

6. Pico della Mirandola, On the Dignity of Man, On Being and One, and Heptaplus,
trans. Charles Glenn Wallis and Douglas Carmichael, intro. Paul J. W. Miller
(Indianapolis and Cambridge: Hackett Publishing, 1965), p. 69; Farmer,
Syncretism in the West, p. 15.

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The context in which we do find references to Hermes, in the Ara-
bic and early modern works, is mainly related to practice rather than
theory. Abu Ma‘shar’s Kitab al-Uluf is concerned with looking at histor-
ical events – past and future – that result from astrological cycles; it is
a technical book of astrology without a theoretical exposition. We find
several references to Hermes in the more theoretical Great Introduction;
however, they are found in its practical parts. For example, a chapter on
the decans is claimed to be derived from Hermes, probably referring to
the Hermetic Book on Thirty-Six Decans.52 We find similar Hermetic ref-
erences in the context of magical practice in the Picatrix, whose author
writes that the first Hermes built statues on the banks of the Nile and
founded a city in Egypt with four gates on which he inscribed apotropaic
magical images. The Picatrix refers to Hermes mostly in relation to magi-
cal practices such as nairanjat which are magical concoctions comprising

various complex natural ingredients.53 Many works attributed to Hermes were circulating in the Middle Ages, such as Liber imaginum Lunae, Liber de quindecim stellis, Liber Lunae ex scientia Abel and Liber Hermetis Trismegisti.54 All these astrological and magical works are practical in nature, unlike the Corpus Hermeticum which contains more philosoph-ical and cosmological observations, yet they are derivative and vague.

Fourteen years after the publication of his translation of the Hermetic Corpus, Ficino finished writing the Three Books on Life. As in the case of Abu Ma‘shar’s works and the Picatrix, referencing Hermes is also restricted to the practice of magic not its theory. For example, in a chapter on the powers of the fixed stars, Ficino writes that ‘certain major stars discovered by Mercurius [Hermes] have the greatest power possi-ble, such as: the Mercurial and Venereal Navel of Andromeda in the twenty-second degree of Aries’.55

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Proclus’, pp. 80–1.

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218. Ficino, Three Books on Life, p. 351.
219. Al-Qurtubi, Das Ziel des Weisen, pp. 309–19; Al-Qurtubi, Picatrix,

pp. 188–90.
220. Yates, Giordano Bruno, pp. 52–3.
221. Thomas Aquinas, The ‘Summa theologica’ of St. Thomas Aquinas, trans.

Fathers of the English Dominican Province, 22 vols. (London: Burns, Oats
and Washbourne, 1922), XI, Q. 94, Art. 1, pp. 180–1.

222. Aquinas, Summa contra gentiles, III.Q. 104.8.
223. Copenhaver, ‘Hermes Trismegistus, Proclus’, pp. 80–6; Copenhaver, ‘Renais-

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and it was even incorporated into the religion of the Sabians of Harran
to whom the author of the Picatrix belonged. The Sabians revered Hermes
alongside Aristotle and added Islamic and Arabic conceptions to the mix.
See Francis E. Peters, ‘Hermes and Harran’, in Magic and Divination in Islam,
ed. Emilie Savage-Smith (Aldershot: Ashgate Variorum, 2004), pp. 185–215
(188); Kevin van Bladel, The Arabic Hermes: From Sage to Prophet of Science
(Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009), pp. 83–104.

41. Abu Ma‘shar, The Thousands of Abu Ma‘shar, trans. David Pingree (London:
Warburg Institute, 1968), pp. 14–15; van Bladel, The Arabic Hermes,
pp. 121–32.

42. Brian Copenhaver, ‘Hermes Theologus: The Sienese Mercury and Ficino’s
Hermetic Demons’, in Humanity and Divinity in Renaissance and Reformation:
Essays in Honor of Charles Trinkaus, ed. John O’Malley, Thomas M. Izbicki
and Gerald Christianson (Leiden: Brill, 1993), pp. 149–82

(162); Florian
Ebeling, The Secret History of Hermes, pp. 61–2.

43. Ebeling, The Secret History of Hermes, pp. 63–4.
44. Yates, Giordano Bruno, p. 6.
45. Hermetica: The Greek Corpus Hermeticum and the Latin Asclepius in a New

English Translation, with Notes and Introduction, trans. Brian Copenhaver
(Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992), pp. 81–2.

46. Yates, Giordano Bruno, pp. 18–19.
47. Garin, Astrology in the Renaissance, p. 65.
48. Kieckhefer, ‘Did Magic Have a Renaissance?’, pp. 199–201.
49. Copenhaver, ‘Hermes Trismegistus, Proclus’, pp. 80–1; Copenhaver, ‘Renais-

sance Magic and Neoplatonic Philosophy’, pp. 351–2.
50. Allen, Plato’s Third Eye, p. 42.
51. Nicholas Clulee, ‘John Dee’s Natural Philosophy Revisited’, in John Dee:

Interdisciplinary Studies in English Renaissance Thought, ed. Stephen Clucas
(Dordrecht: Springer, 2006), pp. 23–37 (30); Frances Yates, The Occult Phi-
losophy in the Elizabethan Age (London and New York: Routledge, 1979),
pp. 1, 88.

52. Abu Ma‘shar al-Balkhi, Kitab al-madkhal al-kabir ila ‘ilm ahkam al-nujum
(The Great Introduction), ed. Richard Lemay, 9 vols. (Naples: Instituto
Universitario Orientale, 1995–6), II, pp. 127–9.

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stars discovered by Mercurius [Hermes] have the greatest power possi-
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twenty-second degree of Aries’.55

All this led Charles Schmitt to conclude that ‘Hermeticism never
becomes a real driving force of any significant cultural movement dur-
ing the Renaissance.’56 Hermes Trismegistus became, to both Arabic
and early modern natural philosophers and occultists, a personification
of a magical nostalgia for a world where divine knowledge was pure
and accessible, unblemished by materiality. In the nebulousness of the
legend of Hermes, the Arabic and early modern philosophers saw differ-
ent personas which fitted within different culturally specific nostalgias
and religious appeal. Francis Peters explains: ‘it is important to realise
that Hermeticism is in fact a historical mirage [. . .] no different from

what passed in Late Antiquity as wisdom of Zoroaster or Apollonius of Tyana'.57

The rhetoric of Hermeticism and Neoplatonic semiology and animated universe were aspects reconciled with Aristotelian causality received from Arabic texts on astrology and magic and/or Latin medieval sources influenced by them. The attribution of a generative and causal role to the stars is a unique element in the Arabic theories of astral influences developed by Abu Ma'shar and applied to magic by al-Kindi and Maslama al-Qurtubi. Their works were very influential on early modern occult philosophy.

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his syncretic philosophical outlook. The Arabic elements in Pico’s works
have often been overlooked even though he was familiar with many

medieval Arabic sources.9 He owned in his library Abu Ma‘shar’s Great Introduction, Flores and De revolutionibus; possibly De radiis; Roger Bacon’s edition of Secretum secretorum; and the Picatrix to which was bound De imaginibus of Thabit ibn Qurra.10 Furthermore, Pico was studying Arabic under the guidance of Flavius Mithridates and he borrowed the Qur’an from Ficino.11 He also had access to Latin medieval works that promul-gated the Arabic theories such as the works of Roger Bacon, Albertus Magnus and Thomas Aquinas.12 This analysis will enable us to note the continuity of medieval Arabic and Latin thought in the early modern period in the case of Pico and also see the innovative reconditioning of medieval ideas in a new context.

The Arabic theories of astral influences have been articulated in three fields often feeding into one another: magic, astrology and meta-physics. Pico tackled all these in various works: The Commentary (1486), a commentary on a poem by Girolamo Benivieni and published posthu-mously, contains ideas on emanationism, causality and the animation of the universe; The Nine Hundred Conclusions, published in Rome in 1486, tackles issues on metaphysics, magic and Kabbalah; the Oration (1486), an essay introducing the Conclusions published posthumously, contains

material on metaphysics, the animation of the universe, the dignity of man, and magic; The Apology (1487), a defence of the controversial conclusions, addresses the legitimacy of magic in relation to Kabbalah; The Heptaplus, an interpretation of Genesis 1:1–27, is mainly cosmo-logical and metaphysical; and finally, The Disputations against Astrology (c.1494) rejects astrological practices and exposes the nature and lim-its of astral influences. To perceive Pico's own ideas on astral influences specifically and the occult generally is not straightforward due to the varied nature and motives behind these works. The Conclusions has a format that does not lend itself to a coherent analysis of Pico's world-view as it is essentially a list of opinions and ideas, stemming from classical, medieval Latin and Arabic authorities and Pico's own conclu-sions, all intended to be debated in Rome in late 1486 in front of Pope Innocent VIII.

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Content Snippet:
7. Kristeller, ‘Giovanno Pico della Mirandola and His Sources’, p. 75.
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10. Pearl Kibre, The Library of Pico Della Mirandola (New York: Columbia Univer-

sity Press, 1936), inv. 44, 1110 (p. 87); inv. 982 (p. 93); inv. 422 (pp. 94–5);
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12. Rutkin, ‘Astrology, Natural Philosophy and the History of Science’, pp. 1,

34–5.
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14. Pico, Oration on the Dignity of Man, pp. 75–6.
15. There are different speculations about the identity of Abdullah, see Pico,

Oration on the Dignity of Man, p. 109, note 3. Pico was studying Arabic under
the guidance of Flavius Mithridates and it is possible that he intended the
generic literal meaning of Abdullah, ‘worshipper of God’, perhaps in refer-

ence to the Prophet Muhammad himself who is cited later in the Oration:
Pico, Oration on the Dignity of Man, p. 131, note 36.

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London: Harvard University Press, 2001–6), V, pp. 137–9; Mebane, Renais-
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33. Farmer, Syncretism in the West, 21.1, p. 303.
34. Farmer, Syncretism in the West, 7.1, p. 251; 19.1, p. 295.
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43. Pico, Commentary, pp. 196–70.
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Kristeller, ‘Giovanno Pico della Mirandola and His Sources’, p. 74.
45. Farmer, Syncretism in the West, 3 > 55, p. 55.
46. Farmer, Syncretism in the West, 11 > 48–9, p. 541.
47. Pico, Commentary, p. 77.
48. Pico, Oration in the Dignity of Man, pp. 227–9, 237, 243.
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50. Farmer, Syncretism in the West, 9 > 3, p. 495; 5 > 45, p. 453.
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12 We can find copies of most of his works in the libraries of Pico della Mirandola and Simon de Phares.13 The wide reception of Abu Ma‘shar’s works and the appropriation of his astrological theory made him the most influential Arabic writer on the topic of astrology in the early modern period.14 The circulation of the Picatrix becomes evident in the high number of manuscripts extant in the libraries of Paris, Florence, Oxford, London, Krakow, Hamburg, Prague and Darmstadt, as identified by David Pingree in his edition of the Latin Picatrix, all copied between the fifteenth and seventeenth centuries.15 Pico owned a copy in his library, and Rabelais mentions it – though disparagingly – and writes that the Picatrix is a devil ‘rector of the diabolical faculty’.16 It was known to Lodovico Lazzaralli (1447–1500), and the physician Symphorien Champier (1471–1538).17 Al-Kindi’s De radiis was also popular among early modern natural philosophers and

occultists and circulated widely on the Continent and in England.18

In the introduction of her edition of De radiis, D'Alverny identifies 20 extant manuscripts and elsewhere she lists another five.19 They were copied between the thirteenth and seventeenth centuries.20 It was admired by Pico della Mirandola, refuted by his nephew Gianfrancesco Pico della Mirandola, and its theory of rays was denounced by Martin Del Rio (1551–1608) in his Investigations Against Magic. In addition to the inherited Latin medieval traditions exemplified by the works of

Albertus Magnus, Roger Bacon and Aquinas, the Arabic texts supplied early modern occultists with a natural explanation of magic's efficacy by introducing astral causality and the astral origins of occult properties.21

The Arabic theories of astral influences with their Aristotelian basis had to find their philosophical place in the syncretic magical thought of the Renaissance alongside the intellectual forces of Neoplatonism and so-called Hermeticism. At first glance they seem to have been competitive and mutually exclusive systems; Eugenio Garin claims that 'there could never be any agreement between medieval philosophy and magic; for medieval philosophy was a theology of order, articulated temporarily as Aristotelianism'.22 Though William Hine detects

a stream of early modern Aristotelianism, he accepts Garin's exclusion of Aristotelianism from magical philosophy, and, insisting on the view that Renaissance magic cannot be naturalized, he remarks: 'in contrast to the Aristotelianism of Renaissance naturalism, Renaissance magic rested on Neoplatonic thought, particularly as represented by the Hermetic Corpus translated and used by Marsilio Ficino, to which Pico della Mirandola had added the cabala'.23 However, as argued here, a continuity can be detected in the magic and astrology of the early modern period traced back to the earlier Arabic and Latin medieval astrological and magic theories, maintaining their Aristotelian premises only now reconciled with newly-revived philosophical streams. Aristotelianism, Neoplatonism, so-called Hermeticism, and Kabbalah as we will see in the next chapter, each supported a different epistemological level of occult thought: the physical, the semiological and the mystical.

On one level, natural philosophers and occultists considered astrology and astral magic as branches of natural philosophy.

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15. There are different speculations about the identity of Abdullah, see Pico,

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losophy: “Ennead” 4.3–5 in Ficino’s “De vita coelitus compranda” ’, in
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In another scenario it is possible that Petrus dictated the Arabic texts for
Adelard who then translated them into Latin immediately.77 The depth
of Adelard's Arabism was also denied by Brian Lawn, and D'Alverny
prefers to say that the Arabic influences are not so obvious in his
thought.78 Though indeed one fruitlessly searches for a citation of an
Arabic text or author, Adelard's concern with astral causality is testi-
mony to the influence of Arabic astrology. Adelard states in On the
Same and the Different that the planets and stars 'are the principle and
causes of the lower natures'.79 As Crombie notes, 'Adelard's use of reason
marks the first explicit assertion in the Middle Ages that recognition of
divine omnipotence did not preclude the existence of proximate natural
causes.'80 It was Abu Ma'shar, with whose works Adelard was acquainted,
who posited that the celestial bodies are causes of all

change in the ter-
restrial world and as a result they are both connected by necessity (sit
iunctus [. . .] necessario).81

Astral causality became the foundation of twelfth-century defences
of astrology as well as cosmological works. Seeking doctrina arabum, the
astrologer Daniel of Morley (d. c.1210) went to Toledo after a disappoint-
ing stint in Paris studying Roman law.82 He tells us that in Toledo he
listened to Gerard of Cremona interpreting Almagest and debated with
him the matter of fatalism in astrology.83 In his Liber de naturis inferiorum
et superiorum, Daniel states that the inferior world is linked by neces-
sity to the superior world. The movement of the celestial bodies causes
diverse effects in the sublunar world.84 Moreover, the celestial world is
the agent of generation and corruption.85 Referring to Abu Ma‘shar, he
states that the motion of the celestial bodies affects the complexion of
generated things as they move from one sign to the other.86 Thus we
see that the Arabic texts that dealt with the way in which the heavens
influence the world below, in addition to medical texts concerned with
external influences on the human body, enriched the concept of causal-
ity in the twelfth century and complemented the mystical perspective
found in the available Latin sources.87

The heavens generate

The most intriguing aspect of Abu Ma‘shar’s astrological theory is the generating agency attributed to the celestial bodies. They function ontologically and as a result impact lives and events astrologically. Abu Ma‘shar’s Great Introduction was the only text available to the cosmologists of the twelfth century that treated the mediation of the planets in the process of generation. Abu Ma‘shar’s ideas on astral generation were

clearly adopted in two cosmological texts: Hermann of Carinthia’s own De essentiis, and Bernard Silvestris’s Cosmographia.

Of central importance to the history of the textual and intellectual reception of Arabic astrology generally and Abu Ma‘shar’s Great Introduction specifically is the activity of Hermann of Carinthia. He was a contemporary of Adelard of Bath, William of Conches and Bernard Silvestris, and may have had direct links with the school of Chartres as he referred to Thierry of Chartres as his teacher.

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founded upon universal/celestial principles. These principles were formulated by Abu Ma‘shar whose astrological theory was adopted in the works of twelfth-century cosmologists, such as Hermann of Carinthia, Bernard Silvestris and William of Conches, particularly in their discussion of astral causation in the process of generation and corruption. Then in the thirteenth century, a new wave of Arabic sources were translated and diffused; philosophical texts such as Avicenna’s Metaphysics, and magical ones such as De radiis, Picatrix and the Secretum secretorum. The theories contained therein supported the belief that astral magic was not superstition but a dignified pursuit that was not always demonic and suspicious. Albertus referred to it as ‘good doctrine’ that interested his Order and we know that the library of the Benedictine house St Augustine held various Arabic texts, including De radiis and De imag-

inibus of Thabit ibn Qurra because of the interest in natural/astral magic among its residents.150 The intelligibility of nature and the heavens and the theoretical legitimacy of magic advocated by figures as Albertus Magnus and Roger Bacon became foundations essential for the coherence of what we can call ‘occult philosophy’; a philosophy that became most widely articulated in the early modern period in the works of Marsilio Ficino, Pico della Mirandola, John Dee and others.

5
Early Modern Astral Magic: Marsilio Ficino

Two intellectual events took place in the early modern period, particularly the fifteenth century, which had a strong impact on Western occult philosophy: the revival of Platonism and Neoplatonism, and the discovery of the Hermetic Corpus. The first led to the re-animation of the universe and endowed a coherence and unity to the universe: the particulars were part of a vibrant whole. This was reinforced by the Hermetic Corpus whose discovery resulted in a kind of mystical humanism that recalls an ancient time when divine knowledge was purer and heavenly wisdom accessible, personified by the legendary Hermes Trismegistus who became a member of the prisca theologia. This brought about a new enthusiasm for esoteric and occult thought.1 Behind both events was the Florentine philosopher, priest and humanist Marsilio Ficino.2

He trans-
lated and interpreted all Plato’s works and wrote
commentaries on them.
He also translated works by Iamblichus, Proclus, Porphyry,
Synesius, and
Psellus.3 In 1460, the Hermetic Corpus was brought to
Florence from
Macedonia by a monk and presented to Cosimo de’ Medici who
then
gave orders to Ficino to translate it. Ficino completed the
first transla-
tion of the Corpus Hermeticum in 1463, and in 1471 it was
printed under
the title of Pimander.4

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Liana Saif's *The Arabic Influences on Early Modern Occult Philosophy* offers a rich account of how Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's thought was deeply informed by Arabic sources—especially within the context of astral magic, metaphysical speculation, and the transmission of the Hermetic tradition. Here are key aspects of Saif's interpretation that illuminate Pico's engagement with Arabic philosophy and magic:

Saif underscores that Pico's —his effort to unify and reconcile different philosophical and religious systems—was not limited to classical antiquity or Christian scholasticism. Rather, it actively embraced Arabic authors such as:

- (al-Falaki), especially *Kitāb al-Madkhal al-Kabīr* (*Great Introduction to the Science of Astrology*), which theorized astral causality and the ontological influence of celestial bodies.

- (*De radiis*), a central text in the theory of natural magic through rays and spiritual emanation.

- and the *Picatrix*, which bound together magical recipes with philosophical ideas.

- and , whose metaphysics and psychology shaped debates over the unity of the intellect and the status of prophecy, dreams, and imagination.

These Arabic thinkers helped Pico frame occult concepts like the *intellectus agens*, the role of the celestial intelligences, and the epistemological structure of magic and prophecy【25:3†source】【25:10†source】.

Saif makes a key distinction between and the of the *Corpus Hermeticum*. She shows that Arabic texts often identified Hermes Trismegistus with the prophet Idris, and that Arabic Hermeticism was primarily —centered on talismans, decans, and astral influences—whereas the Latin *Corpus Hermeticum* was in tone.

Pico was aware of both strands: while he valorized the *prisca theologia* of Hermes, his magical conclusions were

informed just as much by Arabic theories of , , and the metaphysical interplay between *intellectus*, *anima*, and *forma*. This made his “Hermeticism” distinct from Ficino’s more Platonic-Hermetic focus【25:6†source】【25:9†source】.

Pico appropriated Arabic , especially those articulated by:

- : On the structure of necessity, emanation, and the intermediary nature of intelligences.

- : On the unity of the intellect and its relation to the agent intellect, and on the interpretation of dreams as spiritual revelations.

- : On the hierarchy of knowledge, modes of demonstration, and the perfection of man through speculative science.

Saif shows how these concepts were not merely academic for Pico—they undergirded his vision of magic as a , continuous with metaphysics and theology【25:3†source】【25:13†source】.

A major contribution of Arabic sources to Pico’s Conclusions, according to Saif, is the

through the soul's powers:

- Magic becomes possible not through demonic pacts but via the *imaginatio*, *intellectus*, and *phantasia* in correspondence with celestial powers.

- This is grounded in theories from thinkers like , , and , who explain how celestial forms imprint upon the soul, allowing for prophecy, dream interpretation, and magical efficacy.

- Pico's discussions of dreams, spirits, and somnial revelations (e.g. annotated 21.4–21.6) echo Arabic classifications of dream types and visionary cognition 【25:10†source】.

Pico was critical of Ficino's astral determinism, which he found too reliant on of celestial influence. Instead, Pico drew on Arabic authors to stress , asserting the soul's power to transcend astral necessity:

> "Ficino's application of astral causation to particular events and individuals" was too deterministic, whereas Pico, informed by Arabic epistemologies, affirmed that astral influence was real but not omnipotent 【25:3†source】.

Saif shows that Pico stands at the culmination of a long in which astrology, philosophy, and theology were not antagonistic, but . He inherited the legacy of Albertus Magnus, Thomas Aquinas, and Roger Bacon—each of whom incorporated Arabic astrological and magical thought into Christian frameworks 【25:13†source】.

Saif's reading of Pico positions him not just as a Renaissance magus, but as a — someone who internalized and reconfigured Arabic philosophy into a universalizing Christian esoteric system. His *Conclusiones* represent a , in which Arabic philosophers are crucial guides, not marginal footnotes. Far from being derivative, Pico's Arabic citations were the of a new magical humanism that sought to .

Would you like a visual table mapping specific conclusions in Pico's *Conclusiones* to the Arabic sources Saif discusses?

USER

make me a table of Pico's Arabic Sources with Columns titled "Philosopher" (including name, dates, brief bio and

key ideas) "Pico's Take" "Saif's Take" "Challenges" "Projects" (with ideas for research projects) "Games" (with ideas for video games inspired by these themes)

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{"name": "pico_arabic_sources", "type": "document", "content": "
\n\n| Philosopher | Pico's Take | Saif's Take | Challenges | Projects | Games |\n|----------|----------|----------|----------|----------|----------|\n| (Ibn Sina, 980\u20131037) Persian polymath; systematized Aristotelianism with Neoplatonism. Key ideas: Necessary Existent, emanation, unity of intellect, active intellect, psychology of the soul. | Pico critiques Avicenna's account of the intellect but borrows his schema of emanation and spiritual hierarchy. Uses Avicenna's tripartite soul (animal, intellectual, divine) and cosmological model. | Saif emphasizes Avicenna's role in shaping magical epistemology through soul psychology and active intellect. His influence on Pico is metaphysical, not just medical. | Reconciling Avicennian monopsychism with Christian personal immortality. Translating abstract metaphysics into operative occult techniques. | Project: Compare Avicenna's dream epistemology with Renaissance dream magic manuals. Translate lesser-known Arabic Avicennian commentaries into Latin/English. | Game: \"Ladder of the Soul\" - a philosophical puzzle-platformer where the player navigates layers of soul faculties and emanations to

reach divine union. |\n\n| (Ibn Rushd, 1126\u20131198) Andalusian jurist and philosopher; known as \"The Commentator\" on Aristotle. Advocated unity of the intellect, rational interpretation of religion. | Pico engages critically with Averroes, especially his denial of personal immortality and deterministic cosmology. Defends individuality of the soul and reinterpretation of prophecy. | Saif sees Averroes as a foil for Pico's insistence on personal agency and divine grace. Yet Averroes' cosmology deeply informs Pico's metaphysical hierarchy. | Balancing Averroes' rationalism with the mysticism Pico draws from other traditions. Misinterpretations of Averroes by Latin Averroists complicate legacy. | Project: Digital edition of Averroes' Long Commentary on De Anima with Pico's glosses. | Game: \"The Commentator\" - a narrative RPG where the player must mediate debates between philosophers in Córdoba and Florence to shape human destiny. |\n\n| (872\u2013950) Central Asian philosopher and logician. Integrated Aristotelian logic with Platonic cosmology; emphasized perfection through speculative science. | Pico adopts Al-Farabi's refinements of logic and demonstration. Uses his ideas on speculative science as soul-perfection. | Saif highlights Al-Farabi as a crucial bridge between logic and occult metaphysics. His tiered model of sciences enabled magical classification. | Reconstructing lost Al-Farabian commentaries in Latin sources. Understanding technical logical vocabulary within magical contexts. | Project: Analyze Al-Farabi's influence on Renaissance classification of the sciences. |

Game: \"The Ladder of Demonstration\" - a logic-based game of building proofs to unlock higher levels of magical understanding. |\n\n| (Albumasar, 787\u2013886) Persian astrologer; wrote *Great Introduction to Astrology*. Combined cosmology, astral causality, and Neoplatonism. | Pico respects his cosmology but rejects deterministic readings of astrology. Uses Abu Ma'shar to validate celestial influence within providential order. | Saif sees Abu Ma'shar as central to Renaissance magical cosmology. His astrological theory bridges metaphysics and prediction. | Addressing modern bias against astrology. Disentangling Abu Ma'shar's ideas from corrupt Latin translations. | Project: New critical edition of Abu Ma'shar's *Introductorium* with Renaissance annotations. | Game: \"Celestial Mandate\" - a strategic simulation where players read the heavens to guide a civilization through moral and metaphysical choices. |\n\n| (c. 801\u2013866) Philosopher of rays and harmony. Merged Neoplatonism with Islamic theology. Wrote *De radiis* (On Rays), foundational to occult theory. | Pico draws on Al-Kindi's ray theory to support magical influence through sympathy and cosmic order. | Saif shows how Al-Kindi provides the physics behind magical transmission. His ideas are quietly essential to talismanic theory. | Recovering authentic Al-Kindi from spurious texts. Integrating ray theory with modern physics of light/signal. | Project: Map influences of *De radiis* across Renaissance magic texts. | Game: \"Raycraft\" - an action-puzzle game where players craft magical effects

by aligning rays, stones, and planetary forces. |\n\n| (Arabic adaptation of Proclus via Neoplatonists) Misattributed to Aristotle in Latin tradition. Describes causal hierarchy from First Principle to intellects, souls, and nature. | Pico draws extensively from this for metaphysical structure. Supports his conclusions about divine causality, emanation, and the soul. | Saif shows how this text offered a metaphysical justification for magic via intelligible intermediaries. Key to Ficino and Pico alike. | Attribution confusion: Aristotle vs. Proclus. Understanding the text's conceptual system without Christianizing it prematurely. | Project: Annotated comparison of *Liber de Causis*, Proclus, and Pico's *Conclusiones*. | Game: \"Chain of Light\" - explore a metaphysical cosmos by ascending through causal layers, solving symbolic logic puzzles to progress. |"}

TOOL

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Successfully created text document 'Pico Arabic Sources'
which will be referenced in all future messages with the
unique identifier textdoc_id:
'686884fee3948191907fd0a64842fe10'
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Great — I've created a table titled that covers:

- Each philosopher's identity and core ideas,
- Pico's interpretation,

- Liana Saif's insights,
- Conceptual and scholarly challenges,
- Research project ideas,
- Video game design ideas inspired by each thinker's themes.

You can view and edit the table in the to the right. Let me know if you want this turned into a publication, expanded with more figures, or transformed into slides, curriculum, or podcast content.